

Episode 75: Once Upon a Time... (46) – My First Theatrical Feature Film Begins!

The other day, I bought a pair of jeans...

I usually wear Uniqlo's stone-washed-style ones that cost about 3000 yen, but they had gotten quite worn out. Then my wife said, "Wear something more age-appropriate!"

So I went to a jeans speciality store and bought a certain famous brand's "503" or something like that. 8500 yen (tax included). Nearly three times the price of what I used to wear. Well, whether expensive means better - it certainly is different. Though of course, there are plenty of jeans that cost twice as much as these, so I settled on these "503s" as my version of "age-appropriate."

I'm a 45-year-old with an "almost" standard Japanese body type, so naturally I need alterations - hemming the length, the leg length.

It's just heartbreakingly sad (tears). I'd like a discount for the amount they cut off (tears).

Just the other day, I saw my jeans hanging on the balcony next to my wife's jeans, and you know, mine were clearly shorter in the legs (tears). More than frustrating, it was just sad.

So this time I asked them to hem it "a bit long" with some consideration. Then apparently the store's hemming person also added some "consideration," because they're long!

I mean, they're not ridiculously long, but you know how young people wear them long? Like that. But I've never worn them long like that, and since I have short legs, the way the jeans bunch up around my ankles feels really uncomfortable.

Ah, the sadness of middle age (tears). The sadness of being a 45-year-old Japanese man (sobbing).

I'm wearing those jeans as I write this manuscript.

Now then.

Let me write a bit more about old stories.

This is about late summer 1990, while production of *Space Prince Tenjou-hen* (宇宙皇子 天上編) was continuing.

Next to Toei Animation's (東映動画) Oizumi Studio was a shopping centre called "Oz," and on its 4th floor next to a bookstore was a small cafe-like establishment. It's gone now, but back then it was often used by Toei Animation staff. I too ate there once or twice a week.

One day, when I went to that shop for lunch during break time, Director Imazawa (今沢), who directed *Space Prince Tenjou-hen*, was having his meal there. After greeting him, I sat at a table some distance away, and after ordering, I was reading a paperback I'd brought along. Then Director Imazawa came over to sit next to me after finishing his meal.

"Actually, there's a job I'd like to ask you to do"

"Yes" - I closed my paperback and focused on Director Imazawa's words.

"We're going to do a theatrical work. I'd like to ask you to handle the colours."

"Yes!"

"Do you know COO: *From a Far Sea*?"

That was the first time I heard about the theatrical feature *Coo: Far From Home* (Coo 遠い海から来たクー).

"COO: *From a Far Sea*" - a novel by Kageyama Tamio (景山民夫), winner of the Naoki Prize.

Marine biologist Tetsuro and his son Yosuke were living in the Fiji Islands of the South Pacific for Tetsuro's research. One day, while Yosuke was heading to school on the main island by jet ski, he encountered a baby of a mysterious creature resembling a seal washed up on the beach. He brought it home to show his father. Amazingly, it was a baby plesiosaur - a dinosaur that should have been extinct since ancient times. They began life with this baby, named "COO," but danger approached Yosuke and his father from those targeting COO...

Far from not knowing it, I was actually a huge fan of the author Kageyama Tamio and had read almost all of his works. Particularly this "COO: *From a Far Sea*" was one of my favourite books, and I properly owned the first edition.

That it was from the same Kadokawa Shoten (角川書店) as *Space Prince Tenjou-hen*, that it was planned to be a theatrical work of over 90 minutes, that the characters would be by Okura Masahiko (大倉雅彦), that the art director hadn't been decided yet (later decided to be Yamamoto Nizo), that production would start immediately after *Space Prince Tenjou-hen* finished - as Director Imazawa spoke these details quietly, gently, and slowly, I was listening with tremendous internal excitement.

I myself had never done anything but minor assistance on feature theatrical works, but being able to participate as a main staff member in "movies" like *Galaxy Express 999* (9

9 9) or *Space Battleship Yamato* (ヤマト) was exciting just by itself, and that it was "COO" - I couldn't help but be excited.

"Yes! I definitely want to do it!"

I felt that Director Imazawa had evaluated my work during these two years of working hard on *Space Prince Tenjou-hen* and was giving me this opportunity. No matter what kind of work, if you continue trying to do good work and produce results, there will always be people properly watching. I've continued to believe this and still do today, and this was one such instance.

Then, when *Space Prince Tenjou-hen* ended, the staff room was finally set up. This was at the end of 1991.

Around that time, I had *Dragon Ball Z* theatrical work coming up (*Dragon Ball Z: Clash! 10 Billion Power Warriors*, directed by Nishio Daisuke), and I joined COO overlapping with the final push of that work.

My first job was creating image stills for the work. The task was to create 2-3 stills from famous scenes around the beginning of the novel for some kind of presentation.

In a studio room, first we had a meeting with just Director Imazawa, Okura-san, and myself. In front of us were key frames drawn by Okura-san - dynamic artwork showing the protagonist boy kicking up waves as he rides a water bike across the ocean.

However, what was drawn there wasn't the Japanese boy Yosuke, but a foreign boy - clearly a white boy.

(09.01.13)